

We live in an era of science and technology where man thinks he can control everything. In fact, Hashem gave us a mitzvah of (בראשית א' כ"ח) to control and to run the world for the betterment of mankind. However, we often take that too far and we fall into the trap of (8:17) בְּחַי וְנִעְצָם יְדֵי עֲשֵׂה לִי אֶת הַחֵיִל הַזֶּה. Hashem constantly sends us reminders that this not true. Titus said, "Hashem, You can only defeat me on water. You can't defeat me on land." Hashem said, "Oh yeah? Get onto land and a tiny little gnat will take care of you."

We live in a culture where everything belongs to us and we believe we're in charge of everything. Hashem sends a tiny little virus called Covid and all of a sudden the world grinds to a halt. But this בְּחַי וְנִעְצָם yetzer hara is in every generation, not just now. We need constant reminders that we have to limit our vista and say "Hashem, with your help, I can do anything. B'ezras Hashem I can make a parnassa, b'ezras Hashem I can help a sick person get better."

In this week's פרשה of עקב is the second פרשה of שמע, קריאת שמע, and it contains a beautiful but subtle example of what it means to know our limits. The pasuk goes as follows: וְהָאֲדָמָה לֹא תִתֵּן אֶת יְבוּלָהּ וְאֲבֹדָתָם מִהֶרָה מֵעַל הָאָרֶץ הַטְּבָה אֲשֶׁר ה' נָתַן לָכֶם. These particular five words, וְהָאֲדָמָה לֹא תִתֵּן, would be more grammatically correct if it was written תִּתֵּן יְבוּלָהּ, because the word יְבוּלָהּ means אֶת, so the word אֶת is unnecessary. Why did the torah use this extra word אֶת?

אֶת מה שאתה מוכיל לך, our teacher, our guide, our ultimate all-time rebbi, say on this pasuk? - כְּעִנְיִן שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר זְרַעְתֶּם הַרְבֵּה וְהִבָּא מְעַט. No matter what you try to do, you will plant a lot and nothing will come out. Why? Because we think we can do anything with technology. If Hashem doesn't send us rain, it doesn't matter, we'll dig an irrigation ditch. We'll bring in water. We'll make water out of saline water, which is what the Israelis are doing. We'll be able to find ways and means of doing it. Hashem says, "Is that what you think?" The truth is if we want to get something done, it is only b'ezras Hashem.

The word אֶת represents 'א to 'ת, which means everything in the entire world is only if it comes through Hashem. Yes, וְכַבְּשָׁהּ, Hashem wants us to control the world, to conquer the world and to take care of it, but only if we keep saying b'ezras Hashem. In that זכות, we'll have גְּרוּסָה הצלחה in עבודת הבורא and fulfill our תפקיד in this world.

